

director, Aicon Gallery. On the lines of a trade event, Art Mumbai will offer industry perspective with speaker series, knowledge-sharing and networking events.

When asked how the seed of the idea for Art Mumbai germinated, Chawla says, "I've been dedicated to the idea of establishing an art fair for quite some time. My professional association with Dinesh [Vazirani] had led us to contemplate the notion earlier. However, the outbreak of Covid-19 halted our plans, and three years went by before a fresh opportunity emerged. Early last year, we revisited the conversation about effectively addressing a noticeable void in the local art scene. Creating Art Mumbai was a chance for us to be trailblazers in this endeavour."

Trailblazers they certainly are. Dinesh observes, "Our goal is to provide our audience with a comprehensive understanding of the diverse world of artistic expressions in India. Through the array of experiences curated at Art Mumbai, we aspire to inspire visitors to view art not merely as an external entity, but as an integral part of their lives."

And it is not just about artworks on display. It will be the world seen through the prism of art and culture. Dinesh explains, "The speaker series, a fashion show, a conversation with a Bollywood celebrity, musical performances and interesting cuisine are some of the ancillary events that shall make Art Mumbai an even more vibrant event that captures the city's cultural landscape." ■

Priya Pathiyan

ART

Art in Three Dimensions

With a major retrospective by Vadehra Art Gallery, artist **A. Ramachandran**'s sculptures finally get the attention they deserve

You may know A. Ramachandran (1935–) for his large, colourful and arresting canvases that make ample use of archetypal Indian imagery. Less known are his sculptures, although the artist has been creating them alongside his paintings over the years. "Even though I have created so many sculptures, they were always exhibited along with my paintings, so they did not get their due prominence. Besides, the interest in seeing and buying sculptures was never as popular as in the case of paintings and drawings," he says.

Now, a major exhibition–*Ramachandran: A Retrospective of Sculptures*–curated by Delhi's Vadehra Art Gallery (on view at Shridharani Art Gallery until October 29 and at Vadehra Art Gallery until November 22) will bring together around 80 sculptures by the veteran artist. Ramachandran, who was trained at Kala Bhavan in Santiniketan under the likes of Ramkinkar Baij and Benodebehari Mukherjee, is deeply influenced by classical Indian art, Nandalal Bose in particular. "The idea of this exhibition is to make the unnoticed qualities of my sculptures apparent by making it an exclusive experience of this medium," says Ramachandran.

While the final sculptures are in bronze, they begin life in clay. "The flexibility of the image and the fluidity of the work can only be achieved by the way you handle the clay," he says. "On my part, I do my work in clay till I am satisfied and then hand over to my assistants to cast them in metal, over which I don't have much control. So the quality of the sculpture has to be perfect in the clay itself so that when it is transferred to metal, the originality of my creation is not lost." Ramachandran has also created some terracotta sculptures by baking the clay images.

Trained at Kala Bhavan in Santiniketan, Ramachandran is deeply influenced by classical Indian art, Nandalal Bose in particular

As for the theme, the sculptures echo the artist's work in other mediums. The images that appear and reappear in his work are based on his observations of tribals around Udaipur and elsewhere in Rajasthan, as well as his research into Indian traditional wall paintings, folk traditions and South Indian bronzes. "My sculptures are parallel statements of what I do as a painter. They are all the same thought process invented and reinvented through different media and materials. In more than half a century of my art practice, my works are always interrelated and are not separate entities," says Ramachandran. ■

Amit Dixit

